Kitty-Cat

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50905090.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by Largemovingtorb

Summary

Shadow Weaver is furious---what is supposed to be a box full of soil for her secret garden turns out to be a strange and unwanted child.

But what is an inconvenience for a bitter old witch turns out to be a wonderous first meeting for a lonely little girl.

The course of two lives is changed irrevocably, the ramifications of which are felt for years to come, shifting the universe's balance for the better.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Having just orchestrated the defeat of the first Princess alliance, Shadow Weaver decided it was time to relax. The task of thwarting the rebels' attempts at unity had been the largest the old witch had ever set herself against; only through her cunning and black arcane arts had she seen it to completion.

Besides the physical and mental challenges, it had been an emotionally taxing trial as well; amongst the many captured rebels had been Shadow Weaver's old student, Micah. Seeing the young boy as a grown man had stirred old emotions in her old heart—it was a good thing a mask covered her withered face, for she wanted no one to see the tears as Micah was resigned to his fate on Beast Island.

With a glass of bitter red wine in one hand, Shadow Weaver seated herself at her workbench within her secret chambers. From behind her, the resonating hum of the Black Garnet bathed the old woman in its dark majesty as she considered the unopened package—the much-needed soil shipment from Plumeria. The dirt in the Fight Zone was so dry and devoid of sustenance, and soon her lilies and daisies in her secret garden would perish—but thanks to what lay before her—that would not happen.

Taking a delicate sip, Shadow Weaver took a moment to enjoy the rich dry flavor before lifting the blade to cut the adhesive sealing the top of the cardboard box. Micah's face kept appearing within her mind's eye—not the face she had just seen—but the young boy she so fondly remembered. There had been so much potential there, not just for him but for her as well. They could have done so many great things together; if it weren't for her impatience in pushing him too soon and the foolishness of Norwyn, Etheria would have been a much different place than it was now.

But there was still a chance for that—not with Micah, of course—but with her new protégé, Adora. Yes, things will be much different this time; Shadow Weaver just had to make sure she laid the groundwork before pushing the young girl towards destiny—but first—she needed to tend to her garden.

Opening the four flaps at the top of the box, Shadow Weaver placed her nose over the opening and inhaled deeply, expecting the aroma of fresh, rich dirt.

“Ugh!” She exclaimed, her nostrils immediately assailed by an animal funk.

Taking a closer look inside the box, Shadow Weaver’s eyes narrowed in fury as they spotted the source of the offensive smell. Instead of the rich potting soil she needed for the secret garden, a furry face and two miss-match eyes peered up at her.

“What in the name of the seven infernal flames are you!?” Shadow Weaver cried. “I was hoping for dirt—but what I got was you!”

The eyes within the box widened at her words, becoming two round saucers of fear upon hearing the anger in her voice. Shadow Weaver softened slightly, seeing that it appeared to be a child within the box—of what species, she could not discern. It was covered in fine cinnamon fur—two long black ears poked out from either side of a head crowned by a mane of stone-gray hair.

“Do you speak? Where are your mother and father?” She asked, her voice kinder now.

The creature tilted its head, reaching up towards Shadow Weaver with a small hand, fingers tipped by black claws.

“Mufher?” It asked tentatively.

Shadow Weaver jolted, terror coursing through at the prospect of that word being directed at her; once again, Shadow Weaver was forced to think of Micha and the mistakes she made with him.

“Oh, hell-nooo!!!” She shouted.

Hurriedly, Shadow Weaver closed the four flaps of the cardboard box over the creature’s face before it could speak any more offending words. There was a slight whine as she lifted the box

roughly, tucking it under the crook of her arm and hurrying towards the exit of her chambers.

"I know what to do with you!" Shadow Weaver said.

She stormed down the hall, moving as fast as her old feet could take her toward the dormitories where the war orphans were kept. A scratching came from within the box—a desperate sound—as if whatever was within wanted very badly to get out.

"Stop that!" Shadow Weaver yelled, shaking the box.

Instead of crying with dismay, the creature within hissed viciously, making the old woman crack a small, cruel smile.

"Ah! I see you have some spirit! It will serve you well here in the Fright Zone!" She said, entering the bunkroom.

Looking up and down the neat rows of bunk beds, Shadow Weaver took in the dismal living quarters set aside for the Horde's newest generation of soldiers. She was eager to discharge this newest inductee as soon as possible, wanting to hunt down the person responsible for losing her delivery and punish them.

"You! Come here!" Shadow Weaver said to the first child she spotted.

A little girl dressed in the outfit of a junior cadet came forth, looking up at the larger woman with fear in her eyes.

"Yes, Sadow Weeber?" She said.

"Which one are you? Savina? Amalia?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"I'm Lonnie," the little girl said, pointing at herself proudly.

"Whatever," Shadow Weaver said, looking around. "Where's Adora? I have something for her."

Shadow Weaver placed the cardboard box on the bed she knew was Adora's; this would be a good test of the girl's fortitude. Shadow Weaver had traveled all over Etheria and had never seen a creature like this before. Whatever it was, it did not belong here in the Fright Zone—therefore—it was not meant to survive. It would be an excellent lesson to teach Adora about the hardships and cruelties of life—not to get too attached for it would only lead to pain and anguish.

"I dunno where Dora is Sadow Weeber," Lonnie said with a shrug.

Shadow Weaver dismissed this with a wave of her hand.

"Nevermind! Just make sure you tell her to take care of this!" She said, pointing a clawed finger at the box.

"Adora is responsible for what is inside,"

* * *

Skipping into the dormitory, Adora cast about for any playmates—seeing Lonnie sitting on her bed—she hopped over to her, suddenly confused by the strange object next to her friend.

"What's that, Lonnie?" Adora asked, pointing.

Lonnie hopped off the bed, seeming very eager to be somewhere else.

"I dunno, Dora. Sadow Weeber left it for you. She said you nee ta care for it." Lonnie said.

Now that she had a closer look, Adora could see it was a cardboard box, the four flaps at the top neatly folded together.

"What's in it?" Adora asked.

"Dunno. What eva in-nit is real mean! It growls!" Lonnie said, walking away. "Bye, Dora, see you at dinna!"

Adora waved briefly as Lonnie exited the dormitory; moving next to the box, she gave it a tentative poke with her finger.

Nothing happened.

Adora lifted the box from the bottom, just enough so one side tipped; inside, there was a sound like sliding nails, followed by a low growl.

Adora placed the box gently back down—abruptly—the growling faded, becoming softer, like weeping. She decided on a different tactic; placing one ear against the side, Adora knocked gently on the side.

"Hello? Are you okay in there?" She asked.

No answer was forthcoming, just a series of sniffles followed by a rustling—but the crying stopped.

"I'm going to let you out," Adora said, climbing onto her bed to stand over the box. Prying apart the four folds, Adora opened the mysterious package—what she discovered was the most magnificent thing she had ever seen in her young life.

What at first she thought was a ball of dark gray fuzz slowly unfolded, revealing the prettiest eyes Adora had ever seen; one was sky blue while the other was gold—both were slitted, like a kitty-cat. The eyes blinked at her as the face they were set in tilted. Looking closely, Adora saw that whatever was in the box was covered by cinnamon-colored fur—it looked soft and fine—making her want to reach out and touch it. Knowing that was rude behavior, Adora instead held her hand out—the standard greeting taught to her by the Horde.

"Hi! I'm Adora!" She said, almost breathless in excitement.

The head tilted again as a hand reached out; looking closely at the fingers, Adora saw sharp black claws, making her suddenly nervous for her own hand. But the hand did not grasp hers—

instead—the claws slid over her bare palm; it was done so gently—like a whisper—tickling Adora's skin and making her giggle.

"That was funny!" She said. "Is that how people say hello where you are from?"

Another head tilt followed by an incomprehensible expression; the feline eyes watched her, full of curiosity and wonder.

"Mufher?" It said.

Adora immediately shrieked with laughter—*it thought she was its mother!*

"Noooo! I'm not your mother—I'm Adora!" She explained.

"Ador-RA?" It said, emphasizing the last syllable in a kind of growl. The words were spoken in a strange accent—almost musical—and Adora realized she had never heard it before.

"Yeah!" Adora said happily. "I'm not your mother, but I can be your friend—would that be nice?"

There was no answer from the pretty eyes, only a blank incomprehension; Adora realized that whatever this person was, they couldn't understand her words.

"How about you come out of there?" She said, beckoning with her hands.

Immediately the box tilted over, dislodging the occupant onto Adora's bed; her earlier amazement turned to elation upon seeing a long furry shape twisting from the person's behind.

"Wow! You have a tail!" Adora exclaimed. "That's so awesome!"

The cinnamon face turned to regard Adora's pointing finger, then smiled, revealing four small fangs. Adora wanted to scream with delight.

“Are you a kitty-cat?” She asked.

“Kitty-CAT?” It repeated.

Adora nodded, pointing back at them.

“Kitty-cat,” she said, then pointed a thumb back at herself. “Adora,”

“Kitty-CAT,” it repeated, placing a hand on its chest.

“Yeah!” Adora exclaimed happily before taking in the rest of the person.

They were very disheveled and dirty; Adora was uncertain if their hair was supposed to be that big and bushy—it looked in need of a good brushing. Covering their body was an outfit comprised of strips of material—like bandages—overlapping each other. The strips were coming apart and peeling off the person’s body—thinking quickly—Adora came up with the only solution that made sense to her.

“Come with me. Let’s get you cleaned up!” She said, taking the person by the hand and pulling them along behind her. Entering the shower stalls, Adora was relieved to see them empty; she promptly removed the person’s strange clothes—piece by piece. The strips came apart easily enough, emitting dancing green sparks which tickled Adora’s nose and made her giggle. When the entirety of the outfit lay in a pile on the floor, Adora took in her new friend’s chubby body, immediately noticing that ‘it’ was a little girl—just like her.

“Okay! Time for the wet part!” Adora said, placing her hand on the shower knob.

A steaming spray of water lanced out, splashing on the floor near her friend’s clawed feet. Instantly, the little girl leaped away from the jet with a hiss; Adora watched wide-eyed as the dark gray tail doubled in size, becoming large and bushy as it beat the air in irritation.

“Okay! Okay!” Adora cried, quickly turning the shower off. Turning to the little girl, Adora was crestfallen to see mistrust glinting in her feline eyes.

“Stupid!” Adora said to herself, closing her eyes to slap a hand against her forehead.

“Everyone knows kitty-cats hate water! I’m stupid!”

Just as she was about to strike herself again, two soft hands grasped her own, holding it fast. Opening her eyes, Adora saw the little girl beside her, holding her hand against her cinnamon chest. There was a vibration there, matched by a pleasant thrumming sound—she was purring!

“We are going to be good friends, Kitty-Cat!” Adora said, beaming.

The little girl matched Adora’s smile with one of her own.

“Kitty-CAT, Ador-RA—friends,” she said.

Adora nodded vigorously, noticing that her friend’s accent seemed to be vanishing—like she was picking up Adora’s own in mimicry.

“Hey, you hungry?” Adora said, miming the act of eating.

The little girl nodded vigorously, her stomach emitting a rumble as if on cue.

“Okay, that’s perfect; it’s almost dinner time!” She said. “But first, let’s get you dressed!”

Adora picked up one of the pieces of the outfit, wondering how she would get it back on the little girl. Putting two of the pieces together, Adora was not surprised to see them fall apart when she put them on the little girl’s shoulder; they drifted down limply, settling back into the pile.

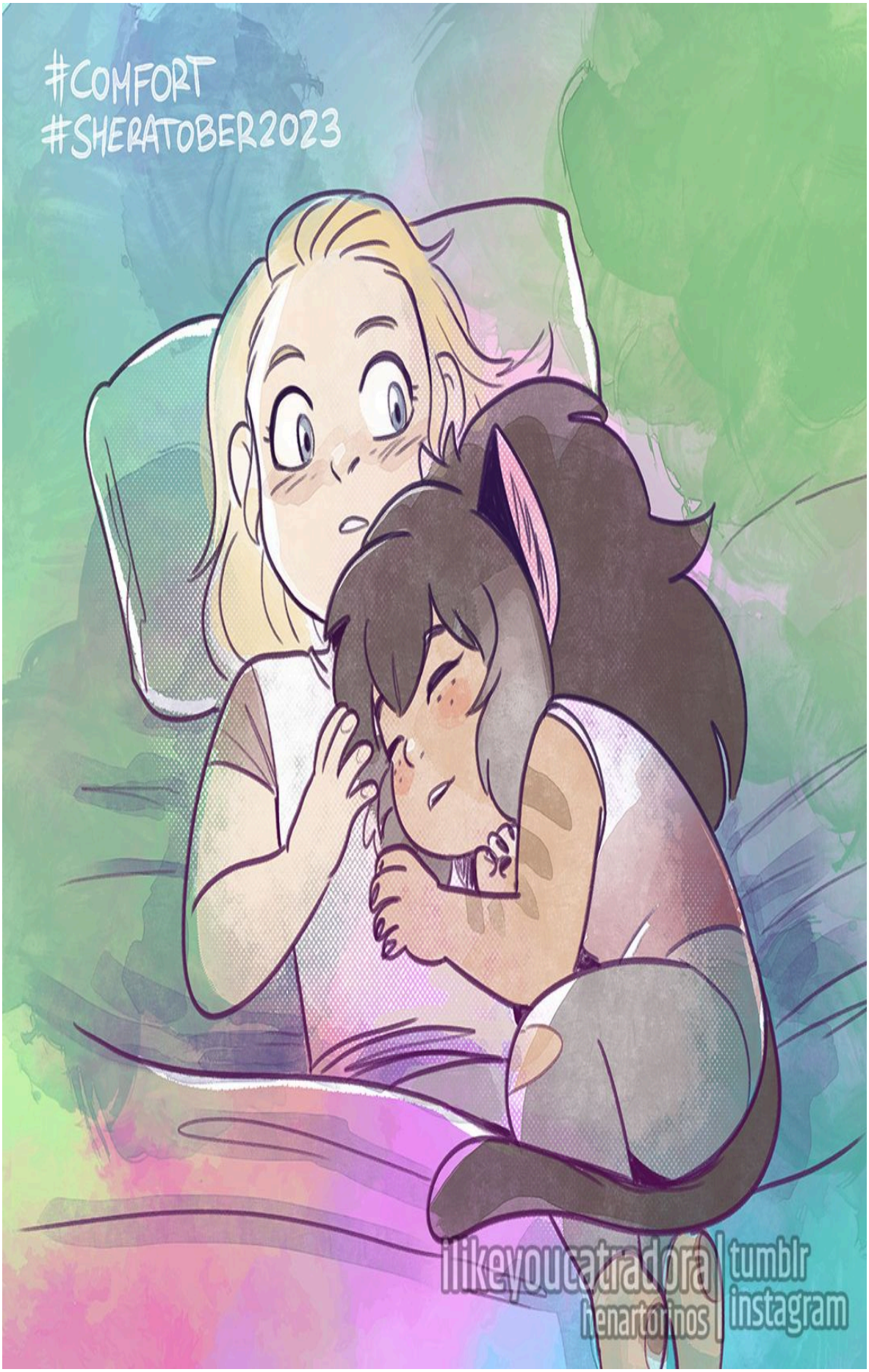
“Maybe we can get you some of my old clothes,” she said hopefully. “I can cut a hole in the pants for your tail!”

* * *

Later that night, after the awkward introduction of ‘Kitty-Cat’ to her friends at dinner, Adora lay on her bed, rethinking the day’s events as she tried to fall asleep. Her new friend was above her on the top bunk, Adora having asked the previous occupant—Kyle—to move. She couldn’t explain it, but Adora felt a special connection to Kitty-Cat and knew the new girl felt the same. It was best that Kitty-Cat was close to her—for the new girls’ comfort, of course.

Hearing movement above her, Adora discerned two gleaming eyes peeking down at her in the gloom of the dormitory. The eyes abruptly flipped, followed by a scrabbling as Kitty-Cat slid down the bedpost to land softly on her bed.

“Wha—?” Adora exclaimed as the little girl crawled under the blankets to snuggle into her side. One of Kitty-Cat’s long ears was tucked under Adora’s chin as the bulk of the little girl’s mane rested against her face. It was not unpleasant—in fact—it was quite nice; everything about Kitty-Cat was soft—something she was in great need of in the hard reality of the Horde.


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What Adora couldn't figure out was what the little girl was currently doing; alternating between her two hands, Kitt-Cat was pressing her fingertips into Adora's side. She could feel just the bare hint of the claw points against her skin—but it wasn't painful—and Adora could tell it was a form of intimate reassurance for her new friend.

Kitty-Cat began purring again, drawing Adora into the spell of comfort; lazily, she realized how lonely her young life had been. Sure, she was in a bunkroom surrounded by other sleeping children—but something was missing.

Adora knew then what that missing ingredient was; it was right next to her, cuddling her, pulling Adora into sleep's embrace with her sweet music. She felt fortunate that life had brought Kitty-Cat to her—things would be much different with her new friend at her side.

"Good night, Kitty-Cat," Adora said dreamily.

"G'night, Ador-RA," the little girl answered, the words spoken around purrs.

Adora smiled, then fell asleep.

* * *

"I tink Kitty-Cat need a real name,"

Adora turned to regard the person who spoke—it was Kyle—sitting across from her at the breakfast table in the Horde Mess Hall. Next to him was Rogelio, and across from him, Lonnie. The topic of the discussion was next to Adora, licking at one of her hands with a wet pink tongue as she appeared to be ignoring everyone.

Adora knew better; it had been three days since her arrival, and already Kitty-Cat had a wide vocabulary—she could speak and understand simple sentences and definitely knew her name by now. Also—and to Adora's disappointment—Kitty-Cat's strange

accent had utterly disappeared; she spoke like everyone else in the Horde now.

“Wha is wrong with her name—Kitty Cat is cute,” Lonnie said.

Adora had to agree with Lonnie—it was a cute name for a very cute person—but most of all, *she* had been the one to give her the name.

“Yeah! What's wrong with the name I gave her!?” Adora said defiantly.

Kyle shrugged, looking for support from his constant companion, Rogelio, who growled in his guttural lizard language, seeming to explain something in detail which no one could understand.

“I dunno,” Kyle said reluctantly. “It’s a baby word—the Horde says we ain’t babies no more,”

Adora saw the truth in that; just the other day, one of the instructors, Force Captain Cobalt, scowled when Adora referred to the new girl as Kitty-Cat. She wanted her new friend to do well in the Horde; perhaps a new name would be better.

“Kitty-Cat,” Adora said, getting her friend’s attention. Her new friend lifted her head from her grooming to regard her, feline eyes no longer filled with cool regard but warmth.

“Ador-RA?” She said inquisitively.

“We are going to give you a new name—you’ll no longer be Kitty-Cat. Do you understand?” Adora said kindly.

Kitty-Cat nodded. “No Kitty-Cat?” She said, pointing at herself.

“Yes,” Adora said, smiling. *Kitty-Cat was so smart.*

“But I think you should choose your name,” Adora finished.

Kitty-Cat shrugged, looking at all her new friends with a blank expression.

“She needs help,” Adora exclaimed. “Kyle, since you want to change her name, what should we call her?”

Kyle shrugged again, seeming to sink into himself at the attention.

“What ‘bout Cat? That not a baby word,” Lonnie said helpfully.

Adora nodded, looking at the new girl and imagining her as just Cat.

“How about it—you, Cat,” Adora said, pointing at the new girl.

Her feline eyes squinted as she seemed to ponder it; finally, she began to speak.

“Me, CAT,” she said, pointing a clawed thumb at her chest. “You Adora-RA”

The new girl’s head tilted as she wrestled with the concept of her new name—abruptly, she spoke.

“I want CAT. RA.”

Adora was surprised to see the confusion on everyone’s faces—to her, it was clear as day.

“CAT. RA. That is not a name; it’s two words,” Lonnie complained.

“Duh!” Adora said, making a face. “It’s not CAT. RA.”

She turned to the one she had named Kitty-Cat—both girls grinning at each other as mutual comprehension dawned on them both.

“It’s Catra!”

THE END

End Notes

I started this story as a game prompt from a Twitter mutual and finished it for a friend. I am sharing it with YOU in celebration of ilikeyoucatradora's Shera-Tober 2023.

Art was done by Henar Torinos, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora, on Tumbler and Instagram for day 17 of Shera-Tober. The prompt: COMFORT.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!